seriousness of the agenda. Attendees included Dr Paul, Cabinet secretary, secretary of the MoHFW, secretary from the Ministry of Shipping, foreign secretary, secretary of Civil Aviation, secretary of Tourism, secretary of Pharmaceuticals, secretary of Information and Communications, secretary of Border Management from the Ministry of Home Affairs, Dr Bhargava, a member from the National Disaster Management Authority, chairman of the Airport Authority and director general of the National Informatics Centre. During the course of the meeting, Dr Mishra asked, 'How many testing laboratories can we expect to increase in two months?'

Someone in the room answered, 'In all probability, Sir, we can have about 70 additional functional labs.' Dr Mishra was not pleased, knowing that the prime minister wanted infrastructure to be ramped up to suit the country's requirements and not merely the government's abilities in 'business as usual' circumstances. *That number is not even close to where we should be*, he thought. (In real time, we were at 151 labs as on 1 April, 254 by 1 May, 676 by 1 June, over 1,056 by 1 July and are over double that number as of August 2021.)

Next, he asked about the availability of masks, PPE kits, ventilators etc.

As a response, a problem of gargantuan proportions emerged; it was the pressing need to augment the availability of masks, PPE kits, sanitizers, test kits and ventilators. From the experience of countries where the virus was spreading rapidly, it was learned that these were essentials which would be needed in large quantities. The grim reality was that India was manufacturing very few N95 masks, the kind which frontline healthcare workers would need. At this point in time, it was estimated that we had only 3.35 lakh N95 masks stockpiled with us. We weren't manufacturing a single PPE kit and had only 2.75 lakh kits in reserve. We were in very short supply of ventilators too—we only had about 20,000 of them and since the virus seemed to have a pneumonia-like debilitating effect on the lungs, ventilators would prove to be life-saving devices.

To the principal secretary, this was not a satisfactory outcome of the meeting at all. He briefed the prime minister of his concerns. The prime minister thought back to his experience in 2015, when he had created small groups of senior bureaucrats and given them common goals to work on which he would discuss with them over personal meetings to instil camaraderie and coordination. The red-tape culture was so disturbing to him that he had spent a lot of time trying to find a way to inspire officers. In